

GREAT GUNSMITHS

WINCHESTER

The repeating rifle was an American invention—created initially in the 1840s by inventors Walter Hunt and Lewis Jennings. It was the Winchester Repeating Arms Company, owned by Oliver Winchester, that developed the idea, manufactured the firearms, and sold them both to American pioneers and hunters, and to armies all over the world. Known for producing high-quality firearms, this company was highly successful, especially in the period between the American Civil War and World War I.



OLIVER WINCHESTER

In 1857, entrepreneur Oliver Winchester found himself in control of the Volcanic Arms Company after many of the other investors pulled out. The repeating firearms produced by the company were impressive compared to the single-shot weapons that were then the norm, but they were not successful, mainly because the cartridges they fired lacked power. Winchester saw the need to improve the company's products and hired Benjamin Tyler Henry to develop a new repeating rifle. Patented in 1860, just before the outbreak of the Civil War, the weapon was the first practical lever-action gun (see p. 116), and, when it came on to the market a year into the war, it made Winchester's name.



HENRY MODEL 1860

THE WINCHESTER AT WAR

During the Civil War, the US federal government bought about 2,000 of Winchester's firearms, which were then known as Henry rifles, after their designer. Individual soldiers purchased still more, realizing that the increased firepower provided by the repeating action gave them a better chance in battle. Soon,

pioneers in the American West were using Henry rifles, too, but Winchester saw that the weapons could be improved, and subsequently introduced the Model 1866 (see p. 117), which had a better loading system and a wooden forestock to protect the user from the hot barrel. These improved rifles helped spread Winchester's fame far beyond the US, particularly when they were used in large numbers by the Ottoman Turks in the Russo-Turkish War of 1877–78. During this conflict, the repeating rifles helped the Turks at the

▼ RUSSO-TURKISH WAR

Russian riflemen (on the right) are seen here firing on Ottoman Turkish troops armed with swords at the battle of Stara Zagora, Bulgaria, in July 1877, during the Russo-Turkish War. Their guns were single-shot, however, and the Turkish forces also had Winchester repeating rifles, with which they eventually defeated the Russians.

“... that damned Yankee rifle that they load on Sunday and fire all week...”

ATTRIBUTED TO CONFEDERATE SOLDIERS

